



ONE HOUR A DAY · NO PERFECT STREAKS REQUIRED

Japanese, Built for Someone Who Loves to Procrastinate

A free, self-guided path — start today, no textbook to order.

The whole plan is engineered around one truth: the habit that survives a lazy day beats the plan that only works on a good one.

要 The two rules that carry everything

READ THESE TWICE

RULE 1 · DON'T BREAK THE CHAIN

15 minutes of flashcards, every single day

Spaced repetition only works daily. Same time, same place — treat it like brushing your teeth, not like studying.

RULE 2 · THE MINIMUM VIABLE DAY

On bad days, do *only* the flashcards

Quitting comes from the all-or-nothing trap, not laziness. Ten lazy minutes keep the streak alive and kill the guilt. That's a win, not a failure.

仮 Phase 0 — Wake your kana back up

WEEK 1–2

Days 1–5

- **Hiragana.** Tofugu's free guide teaches all 46 with mnemonics in an afternoon — you'll recognise most.
- Drill on **Kana Pro** until you read any character in under 2 seconds.

Days 6–10

- **Katakana**, same method, same Tofugu format.
- **The test:** read kana aloud with no chart. When you stop pausing, you're done — drop romaji forever, even if it's not perfect.

日 Your daily hour

MONTH 1 ONWARD

TIME	ACTIVITY	WHY IT'S THERE
15 min	Vocabulary — SRS flashcards	The non-negotiable daily habit. Do this first so it always happens.
20 min	Grammar	The rules that turn a pile of words into real sentences.
15 min	Kanji (inside vocab)	Learn 水 in お水 / 水曜日, never as a lonely character.
10 min	Listening / immersion	Train your ear from day one, even when you understand almost nothing.

Daily total: **60 min** · Lazy-day floor: **15 min** (flashcards only)

道 The road ahead

18-MONTH ARC

Months 1–3

≈ N5

- Grammar: work through **Tae Kim's Guide** in order.
- ~1,000 common words in SRS · ~100 kanji via vocab.
- Goal: read simple sentences, introduce yourself, catch basic phrases.

Months 4–8

≈ N4

- Finish Tae Kim; start reading **graded readers** (Tadoku Level 0).
- Vocab to ~2,000 · kanji to ~300.
- Goal: hold simple conversations, read short easy texts.

Months 9–18

≈ N3

- Shift weight to **immersion** — native content with lookup support.
- Grammar becomes review and gap-filling.
- Goal: understand a lot of daily content, read slowly on your own.

KANA

Tofugu Hiragana / Katakana guides — best free kana intro anywhere

Kana Pro · Real Kana — fast recognition drilling

GRAMMAR

Tae Kim's Guide — complete free course, web + app

Imabi — deep free reference for later

VOCAB & KANJI (SRS)

Anki + Kaishi 1.5k deck — the daily flashcard engine

jpdb.io — free vocab + kanji with SRS & streaks

WaniKani — first 3 levels free, great for kanji

LISTENING & READING

Comprehensible Japanese (YouTube) — beginner immersion

Nihongo con Teppei — free graded podcast

Tadoku readers · NHK Easy News — free graded reading

LOOKUP

Jisho.org — the free JP-EN dictionary

Yomitan — hover-to-translate browser extension

ANTI-PROCRASTINATION KIT

Streak counter — let Anki / jpdb do your discipline

Fixed slot — same 15 min daily, no daily decisions

Why the free self-guided path over a textbook: zero startup friction (no book to wait for), built-in streaks that supply the discipline for you, and a lazy-day escape hatch so one missed session never turns into quitting. Genki suits people who love checking boxes; this suits people who need momentum more than structure.